

2024 USUCGER Annual Meeting

MINUTES

Tuesday February 27, 2024

Vancouver, BC Convention Center

4:00 PM Pacific Time

Jack Montgomery, USUCGER President, Presiding

Attendance:

- Adda Athanasopoulos-Zekkos (Past President), Joseph Coe (Treasurer), Lisa Star, Diane Moug, Kristin Sample-Lord (Webmaster; Ex-Officio), Xenia Wirth, Estefan Garcia, Jack Montgomery (President), and Bret Lingwall (Secretary).
- Also, in attendance were 29 unique USUCGER members and several non-faculty guests including two student travel grant winners. An additional 6 USUCGER members joined online.

Welcome:

- Call to Order at 4:00PM
- Introductions of the board members.

General Committee Business:

- Outgoing members of the board were recognized and thanked. Incoming members (Xenia and Lisa) were welcomed.
- The Board will be creating a new board position: Membership Director. This is to take burden off of the webmaster and treasurer. This position comes from the Board membership.
- An election will be held in Fall of 2024 for two new positions, one junior and one senior. The nominating committee will be formed in August to develop a pool of candidates for the election.
- An NSF informational session was held with Dr. Giovanna Biscontin (NSF ENG-CMMI-ECI program officer).
- Awarded three student travel grants for GeoCongress 2024. There is some interest in expanding travel grants to DFI.
- Other organization updates and announcements
 - DFI will have a specialty track on water related infrastructure this year at their annual meeting. DFI would like to have more students attend, matching the good student attendance at GeoCongress. A new student engagement committee has been formed and is starting to put forth efforts. There are more scholarships and travel grants from DFI opening April 1, 2024... please encourage students to apply. Faculty can watch DFI informational webinars for free to learn more about current deep foundation practice. There are primers on Geotechnical Baseline Reports available from DFI for faculty to use in classroom instruction on site characterization in support of deep foundation design.

- o PDCA would like to support academic needs in pile driving. They would love for faculty to reach out to PDCA members and leads on resources/data/cases for classroom instruction and applied research. PDCA will send out a survey to connect with PDCA on pile driving research so they know who they should be reaching out to, to further pile driving research.
- o ADSC has a Graduate Student Scholarship open right now. The deadline for this will be April 1. The application materials will be sent out by ADSC over the USUCGER listserv. They anticipate giving out 15 to 20 scholarships.
- o Geo-Institute (GI) has new Innovation and President's Awards that will be coming soon. GI will be developing a workforce development workshop to help with the HS → College → Industry → Continuing Education pipeline for geotechnical related industries spanning construction, design, government, and academia. Ellen Rathje is the new International Secretary for ISSMGE. There are two new GI governor positions that need to be filled in 2024. The GI is seeking governors. USUCGER members are encouraged to nominate and be nominated to the GI Board of Governors.
- o IFCEE 2024 is upcoming. If you didn't make it to GeoCongress, please consider attending IFCEE 2024. For faculty that have never seen equipment in action, they will be having equipment demos and showing working platforms and other full-scale equipment in action. This will be very valuable to faculty who need to teach deep foundations but have never been a part of deep foundation construction.

Treasurer's Report:

- Bank Balance of \$38,932, with \$7,265 in Paypal. Total assets of \$46,197.
- The Board expects to support \$22,500 to the Early Career Workshop in 2024 pending NSF funding match.
- The current dues drive is continuing, about 3/4 have paid for the new cycle. Others need to pay soon! There has been a legacy of non-payment that the board is trying to mitigate through a high portion of dues payments.

Webmaster's Report:

- When sending emails, just email all@usucger.org and the entire membership should receive it, pending any moderator approvals by the webmaster.
- Kristen can help with website and listserv problems or questions. Please contact her!
- Please send academic positions to Kristen to post to the website in addition to sending out to the listserv.
- The List of Individual Members Page will be coming back as we finish the dues cycle and start the next dues cycle in 2025.
- Please add USUCGER to the Safe Sender List for your organization or your individual email account to make sure that all emails get through.
- Guidelines for use of the Listserv. We have not had problems with abuse to date, but the board will be developing a "fair use" type language for the Listserv. Any USUCGER members are welcome to contribute their thoughts to the Board.
- It was recommended to the Board that the USUCGER website be modified to add an announcement email archive so that folks can look up a log of all the announcements sent

out. The webmaster will look into this and report for the next meeting of the USUCGER board.

Additional Business:

- Special Projects
 - Update from Iowa State University on the 2023 project: Game-Design Based Learning to Improve Engagement, Achievement and Motivation Among Geotechnical Engineering Undergraduates. Cassie Rutherford and Beena Ajmera are PIs on the award. A demonstration of the progress with game-development researchers was presented to the membership.
 - Significant progress has been made using mixed-methods research, and results of the project will be distributed through the USUCGER website when completed and published in Engineering Education journals.
 - A paper is in the GeoCongress 2024 Proceedings on the preliminary work. Please look up the paper and see how games have helped with undergraduate education.
 - No FY 2024 Special Projects were awarded. A new solicitation for special projects will come out in the Fall.
- Awards
 - The following awards were made, and the awardees were recognized by the USUCGER membership:
 - Early Career Educator: Katerina Ziotopoulou
 - Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion: Shobha Bhatia
 - 2024 will be the search for the Early Career Researcher and Distinguished Service Awards
- Early Career Workshop
 - Was delayed due to the pandemic and now is waiting on funding decision from NSF. Will be held at Texas Austin with Dr. Kumar as the host for the event. The current proposal is pending at NSF and the University of Texas team is in contact with NSF.
- Other USUCGER Initiatives
 - Community College Outreach
 - Diane Moug led the discussion on helping to increase the pipeline of students from community college to 4-year undergraduates into civil, especially geotechnical engineering. The Board feels that this is a potential untapped pipeline of students that can be sold on geotechnical engineering. We first have to establish connections with community colleges, but early feelers to community college faculty and administrators is very positive. Perhaps USUCGER members can create simple geotechnical problems for application into freshmen and sophomore level classes at the community college.
 - “Teach Engineering” website, funded by NSF; PI Beena Ajmera; is a resource.
 - A sub-committee will be formed to make this a large emphasis of the Board for the next years.
 - Webinars for USUCGER members about research funding opportunities will be coming soon. Some of these agencies include:

- USACE-ERDC (scheduled for April 17 at 2pm Eastern)
- DOE
- NIST
- o Graduate School details for perspective students. The Board will be working on materials to help perspective students understand what graduate school is, what it looks like, and what geotechnical graduate school is.
- o Early Career Faculty
 - Matt Evans was not present to discuss

Questions and Comments from the Membership:

- A mid-career development program for mid-career faculty was proposed by Cassie Rutherford.

Adjourn at 5:05 PM after a Motion and Second